

Memory versus Monument Classroom Run Kit

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • History • 30-45 min

Category	History	Time	30-45 min
Difficulty	Medium	ID	memory-versus-monument

Big idea: Public memory and historical knowledge overlap, but they are not the same practice.

One-Minute Teacher Brief

Students compare personal memory, public memorials, and archival evidence as different ways of knowing the past.

Student Prompt

Inspect Memory versus Monument Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Memory versus Monument Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: Fictional memorial: a plaque celebrating a former headteacher beside a diary extract from a student and a board meeting note. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Memory versus Monument Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: Comparison prompt: What does each source ask the public to remember?. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Memory versus Monument Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: Comparison prompt: What does each source ask the public to remember?. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Public memory and historical knowledge overlap, but they are not the same practice.

Actual Lesson Questions

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
1	After inspecting Memory versus Monument Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: look for a clear claim, not just a description.
2	Which exact detail from Memory versus Monument Stimulus A did you use as evidence?	Teacher cue: students should name visible words, data, source features, method features, or contextual clues.
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?	Teacher cue: this is where assumptions, framing, models, or perspective usually appear.
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?	Teacher cue: confidence is data for the debrief, not a grade.
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: push for method, source, context, comparison, or definitions.

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
6	How is public memory different from historical knowledge?	Teacher cue: students should move from the classroom example to a general TOK issue.

Student Task

Use the stimulus cards to complete the observation/inference/evidence/confidence grid, then answer one TOK knowledge question connected to History.

Teacher Key / Reveal

The key move is not the “right answer”; it is the moment students see how public memory and historical knowledge overlap, but they are not the same practice.

- Strong response: separates observation from inference.
- Strong response: names a method, source, model, language choice, context, or perspective.
- Strong response: revises confidence when new evidence or a new criterion appears.
- Weak response: gives only opinion or says “it depends” without criteria.

Student Instructions

- Work silently for the first response so you can notice your own starting point.
- Record one knowledge claim, the evidence behind it, and your confidence level.
- After the reveal or comparison, update your claim in a different colour or column.
- Use the debrief to answer: How is public memory different from historical knowledge?

Setup Checklist

- Use a local or familiar memorial only if the class context is suitable; otherwise use a fictional school memorial.
- Prepare three sources with clearly different purposes.

Example Stimuli or Materials

- Fictional memorial: a plaque celebrating a former headteacher beside a diary extract from a student and a board meeting note.
- Comparison prompt: What does each source ask the public to remember?

Resources To Use

- Resource pack: <resources/memory-versus-monument/index.html>
- Card deck CSV: <resources/memory-versus-monument/cards.csv>
- Visual prompt: <resources/memory-versus-monument/visual-prompt.svg>
- Source comparison chart: purpose, evidence, emotion, omission, reliability.
- Memory/history Venn diagram.

Run Sequence

1. Show a memorial image and ask what knowledge it seems to communicate.
2. Give a personal memory and an archival source about the same event.
3. Students compare purpose, evidence, emotion, and omissions.
4. Groups decide what each source helps us know and what it cannot settle.

5. Debrief the difference between remembering and explaining the past.

Debrief Moves

- Knowledge question: How is public memory different from historical knowledge?
- Can a monument be evidence, interpretation, and argument at once?
- Whose responsibility is it to revise public memory?

Teacher Quick Script

- A memorial is not a textbook page; it is a public act of selection.
- What kind of truth is the memorial trying to preserve?

Exit Ticket

- One thing I first treated as evidence was...
- My confidence changed because...
- A better knowledge question I can now ask is...